

Making sentences interesting

THE BEST PIECES OF WRITING USE SENTENCES THAT ARE CLEAR BUT ALSO INTERESTING TO READ.

A text containing very similar sentences will be boring to read. Using a variety of sentence types with plenty of detail will make a piece of writing more engaging.

Pick and mix

Good writers vary the types of sentences that they use in their work. Lots of short sentences can make a piece of writing monotonous and disjointed. Using some longer sentences instead helps the writing flow and links ideas together. There are three main types of sentences to choose from.

This compound sentence has two main clauses linked by the conjunction *and*.

A monster was on the loose. It came out at night and its howls filled the air. People said that the monster had green fur and red eyes, although no one had ever seen it.

This simple sentence contains the subject *monster* and the main verb *was*.

This complex sentence contains a main clause and a subordinate clause.

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Writing a narrative

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Change of pace

Rather than using a random mixture of sentences, it's possible to select a particular type of sentence for effect—for example, to change the pace or add tension or excitement.

She began to run. The monster followed. Her heart was racing. The monster wasn't far behind. She had to make a decision. She jumped into the lake.

A string of short sentences in a story can create excitement.

Pulling herself out of the water, she could see light from the cottage in the distance. She scrambled up the riverbank, and ran through the mud, under the oak trees, around the bend in the road, and up the path. She was home.

Using a short sentence after a very long one can relieve tension.

"If we don't all gather together and track down the bloodthirsty monster, our children will not be safe on the streets and we will not be able to sleep soundly in our beds. We need to act now."

A long sentence in a speech can reinforce the seriousness of a problem.

Following the long sentence with a short sentence can make a powerful final point.